

Session 15: God Sees Leah

Key Takeaways

- The combined language of “love” and “hate” makes its first appearance here talking about Rakhel and Leah, but it gets picked up by later biblical authors to talk about outcomes for entire groups of people.
- Levi and Judah, the third and fourth sons of the unloved wife, become the fathers of the future anointed leaders of Israel.
- Time and time again, God reveals his heart by elevating the poor and oppressed and treating them as kings and queens.

Yaaqov's Rival Wives and Many Sons

Genesis 29:31-35

- **Yahweh sees** the unloved Leah and gives her 4 sons

Genesis 30:1-16

- **30:1-8 Rival Sisters / Failure: Round 1**
 - Rakhel is jealous of Leah and gives her slave to Yaaqov > 2 sons
- **30:9-13 Rival Sisters / Failure: Round 2**
 - Leah is jealous of Rakhel and gives her slave to Yaaqov > 2 sons
- **30:14-16 Rival Sisters / Failure: Round 3**
 - Rakhel hires out Yaaqov for a night in exchange for mandrakes

Genesis 30:17-24

- **30:17-21** **Yahweh hears** the unloved Leah and gives her 2 sons + 1 daughter
- **30:22-24** **Yahweh remembers and hears** younger Rakhel and gives her 1 son

Genesis 29:31-30:24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The birth narrative of the many sons of Yaaqov is set within the rivalry of Leah and Rakhel, whose sins against each other mirror that rivalry of Yaaqov and Esau.

The narrative opens and closes with God noticing the despondent state of each sister (“and God saw ...” and “God remembered ... and listened ...”), followed by the surprise pregnancy and birth of children (Leah’s first four and Rakhel’s one).

Inside of this “divine gift” frame, there are three failure narratives of the sisters scheming to generate their own blessing, each one patterned after earlier narratives about Abraham, Sarah, and Hagar, or about Yaaqov and Esau.

- Genesis 30:1-7 portrays Rakhel as jealous of her fertile sister, and so she replays the sin of Abraham and Sarah against Hagar. But God responds with the blessing of children.
- Genesis 30:9-13 portrays Leah as imitating her sister in repeating the sins of Abraham and Sarah against Hagar, and again the divine response is the blessing of more children.
- Genesis 30:14-21 combines the rival sisters in a single narrative, so that the discovery of the mandrakes (a cipher for "Edom") becomes the occasion for Leah (the older) to "buy" the blessing of children from her sister Rakhel. In this story, Leah becomes Yaaqov, while Rakhel becomes Esau, trading away her husband for mandrakes.

Yahweh Blesses the Non-Chosen

³¹ And Yahweh saw that Leah was **hated** ,
and he opened her womb ,
but Rakhel was barren.

Leah's 4 Sons

#1 Reuben

³² **And Leah became pregnant and gave birth to a son,**
and she called his name Reuben , (ראובן)
for she said,
“ **Because Yahweh has seen** (ראה) my oppression,
for now my husband will **love** me.”

#2 Shimon

³³ **And Leah became pregnant again and gave birth to a son,**
and she said,
“ **Because Yahweh has heard** (שמע) that I was **hated** ,
and he has also given me this one,”
and she called his name Shimon . (שמעון)

#3 Levi

³⁴ **And she became pregnant again and gave birth to a son,**
and she said,
“Now, **this time** my husband will be **attached** (ליוה) to me,
because I have borne him three sons.”
Therefore his name was called Levi . (לוי)

#4 Yehudah

35 **And she got pregnant again and gave birth to a son,**
and she said,

“ **This time** I will **praise** (אודה) Yahweh.”

Therefore she called his name Yehudah . (יהודה)

And she stopped giving birth .

Genesis 29:31-35. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

In this opening scene, Leah is set on analogy with Hagar, the non-chosen wife of Abraham who is still blessed and given a promise of future seed.

Genesis 16:11-13 NASB*

¹¹ And the messenger of Yahweh said to [Hagar], “Look, you are pregnant and will give birth to a son, and you will call his name **Yishmael (= “El will hear”)** because **Yahweh has heard your oppression**.

¹² And as for him, he will be a donkey of a human. His hand will be against everyone, and everyone’s hand will be against him. And against the face of all his brothers he will reside.” ¹³ And she called the name of Yahweh who spoke to her, “You are **El-Roi (= “El Who Sees Me”)**”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 21:17-18 NASB

¹⁷ And *Elohim* heard the voice of the young one, and the messenger of *Elohim* called to Hagar from the skies, and he said to her,

“What is it, Hagar? Don’t be afraid, because **Elohim has heard** the voice of the young one, in the place where he is.

¹⁸ Get up, pick up the young one, and take him with your hand, because I will make him a nation, a great one.”

In the story of Abraham, Hagar and Ishmael are the non-chosen, but they are favored by Abraham. Their expulsion is a result of Sarah’s jealousy (Gen. 21), so God cares for the non-chosen and also gives Eden blessing to them.

Here in the Yaaqov story, Leah is unloved, so God also blesses her with abundant seed.

The Ancestors of the Messiahs

This story is remarkable as it makes up the center of the center of the Yaaqov story, and it features the birth of the two sons who will become the ancestors of Israel’s two “anointed” institutions: the priesthood and the kingship.

- Levi is the ancestor of Aaron (see Exod. 6:12-28), who will be Israel’s first “anointed” high priest (see Exod. 29:7; Lev. 8:12).
- Judah is the ancestor of David, who will be Israel’s first king to unite the tribes into one people (see 1 Sam. 16, 2 Sam. 4-5).

Rakhel's Scheme to Build a Family

Rakhel's 2 Sons Through Her Slave

¹ **And Rakhel saw that she had not given birth** for Yaaqov,
and she became jealous of her sister;
and she said to Yaaqov,
“Give me sons!
And if not,
I’m going to die!”

² And Yaaqov's anger was hot against Rakhel,
and he said,
“Am I in the place of Elohim,
who has withheld from you the fruit of the womb?”

³ **And she said,**
“Here is my servant Bilhah.
Go in to her,
so she can give birth onto my knees,
and from her I also will be built up.”

⁴ **And she gave to him her servant Bilhah as a wife**,
and Yaaqov went in to her.

#5 Dan

⁵ **And Bilhah conceived and birthed for Yaaqov a son,**

⁶ **and Rakhel said,**
“God has **vindicated** me (דנני),
and also has heard my voice,
and has given me a son.”

Therefore she called his name Dan (דן).

#6 Naphtali

⁷ And **Rakhel's servant Bilhah** conceived again and **birthed for Yaaqov a second son**.

⁸ **And Rakhel said,**
“ **Wrestlings** (נפתולי) of Elohim
I have **wrestled** (נפתלתי) with my sister,
and I have prevailed!”

And she called his name Naphtali (נפתלי).

Leah's 2 Sons Through Her Slave

9 **And Leah saw that she had stopped giving birth** ,
and she took **her servant Zilpah** ,
and she gave her to Yaaqov as a wife .

#7 Gad

10 **And Leah's servant Zilpah birthed for Yaaqov a son**,
11 **and Leah said**,
"By **Fortune** (בגד)!"
and she called his name **Gad** (גד).

#8 Asher

12 And **Leah's servant Zilpah birthed for Yaaqov a second son** ,
13 **and Leah said**,
"By my **blessing** (באשר)!"
For women will call me **blessed** (אשרוני)."
And she called his name **Asher** (אשר).

Genesis 30:1-13. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Sarah didn't trust in Yahweh to provide her with a child. Rakhel is also unable to have children and comes up with the same scheme as Sarah.

Genesis 3:6 Instructor's Translation

And the woman (האשה) saw (ותרא) that the tree was good for eating ... and she took (ותקה) from its fruit and she ate and she gave (ותתן) also to her husband (אישה) with her and he ate.

Sarah and Hagar	Rakhel and Bilhah
Gen. 16:1 And Sarai ... had not given birth for Abram	Gen. 30:1 And Rachel saw (ותרא) that she had not given birth for Jacob and she was jealous of her sister
Gen. 16:2 And Sarai said... "Behold (הנה), Yahweh has bound me from giving birth. Please go into my slave (שפחה). Perhaps I can be built up from her (בנה + מן)." And Abram listened to her voice (שמע + לקול).	Gen. 30:2 And Jacob said, "Am I in the place of God who has withheld from you the fruit of the womb?" Gen. 30:3 "Behold (הנה), my maid-slave (אמתי) Bilhah, go into her and she will give birth upon my knees, and I will be built up, me too, from her (בנה + מן)"
Replaying Genesis 16. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

Sarah and Hagar	Rakhel and Bilhah
Gen. 16:3-4 And Sarai took ... her slave (שפחה), and she gave her to (ותתן ל) Abram as a wife (לאשה). And he went into her ...	Gen. 30:4 And she gave to him (ותתן לו) Bilhah her slave (שפחה) as a wife (לאשה) and he went into her.
Gen. 16:4 And [Hagar] became pregnant and when she saw (ותרא) she was pregnant, her mistress was cursed in her eyes.	Gen. 30:5 And [Bilhah] became pregnant
Gen. 16:11 “Behold you are pregnant, and you will bear a son and call his name Yishmael (ישמעאל) for Yahweh has listened (שמע) to your suffering.”	Gen. 30:6 And Rachel said “God has judged for me and also he has listened to my voice (שמע + בקול) ...”
Gen. 16:12-14 Hagar discovers at “Ber-lahai-roi” (באר לחי ראי) that she will give birth to Ishmael, who will be a “wild donkey of a man” (פרא אדם), and his hand (ידו) will be against everyone.”	Gen. 30:5 Bilhah gives birth to Dan Judg. 15:14-16 The most famous “Danite” is Samson, who “came to Lehi (לחי), and he found the jawbone (לחי) of a donkey and he sent out his hand (ידו) and he struck with it a thousand men.”
Replaying Genesis 16. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

Rakhel’s actions with Yaaqov are an intensified replay of Sarah’s actions with Abraham, as well as a contrast with Rivqah from Genesis 25:21.

- Sarai is barren and schemes her own way to produce the promised seed, accusing Abraham when the plan doesn’t work.
- Rivqah is barren, but Yitzhaq intercedes for her, and Yahweh restores fertility to her womb.
- Rakhel is barren, accuses her husband for not giving her sons, and then schemes her own way (identical to Sarah’s) to produce seed.

Of Mandrakes and Bowls of Stew

¹⁴ And Reuben went in the days of wheat harvest, and he found mandrakes in the field, and brought them to his mother Leah.

And Rakhel said to Leah,
“Please give me some of your son’s mandrakes.”

15 **And she said to her,**
"Is it a small matter for **you to take my husband?**
And would **you also take my son's mandrakes** ?!"
And Rakhel said,
"Therefore, **he can lay with you this night,**
in the place of **your son's mandrakes** ."

16 And Yaaqov came **in from the field** in the evening,
and Leah went out to meet him
and she said,
"You must come in to me,
for I have surely paid **a wage (שכר)** for you,
with **my son's mandrakes** ."
And **he lay with her that night.**

Leah's 2 Sons + 1 Daughter

#9 Yissakhar

17 **And Yahweh listened to Leah ,**
and she became pregnant and gave birth to a fifth son,
18 **and Leah said,**
"Yahweh has given **my wage (שכרי)** ,
in that I gave my female slave to my husband."
And she called his name **Yissakhar (יששכר)** .

#10 Zebulun

19 **And Leah became pregnant again and gave birth to a sixth son to Yaaqov,**
20 **and Leah said,**
"Yahweh has **gifted** me (זבדני) with a good **gift** (זבד).
This time my husband will **exalt** me (יזבילני),
because I have birthed six sons for him."
And she called his name Zebulun (זבולון).

#11 Dinah

21 And afterward she gave birth to a daughter,
and she called her name **Dinah** .

Rakhel's 1 Son

#12 Yoseph

22 **And Elohim remembered Rakhel ,**

and Elohim listened to her ,

and he opened her womb ,

²³ and she conceived and gave birth to a son,

and she said,

“God has gathered away (אסף) my humiliation.”

²⁴ And she called his name Yoseph (יוסף),

saying,

“May Yahweh add (יסף) to me another son.”

Genesis 30:14-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

The mandrake episode (Gen. 30:14-16) is a condensed replay (and elaborate wordplay!) of Yaaqov's deception of Esau with the red stew and of Lavan's deceit concerning Yaaqov's “wages.” It also develops the themes of Genesis 3, where the sought-after blessing is exchanged for food.

Yaaqov's Deceptions and Lavan's Counter-Deceptions	Leah “Hires” Yaaqov for a Night
Yaaqov used stew to deceptively take the birthright from Esau	Leah used mandrakes to deceptively take the promised seed from Rakhel
Gen. 25:29 Esau was coming in “from the field” when Yaaqov tricked him with the stew	Gen. 30:14, 16 Reuben found mandrakes “in the field”, and Leah tricked Rakhel and found Yaaqov when he came in “from the field”
The stew is “red red” (<i>ha’adom ha’adom</i> / האדם האדם)	The mandrakes (<i>duda’im</i> / דודאים)
Gen. 29:15 Lavan cheats Yaaqov out of his “wages” (שכר)	Gen. 30:16 Leah “hires by wage” (שכר) Yaaqov for a night
Of Mandrakes and Bowls of Stew. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).	

Leah the older sibling usurps the younger, chosen sibling with exotic food (wordplays with Edom from Gen. 25).

“Hebrew *duda’im* has long been identified with the *Mandragora, officinarum*, which grows wild in the fields. Its small, yellow, tomato-like fruit ripens during March and April. Chemical analysis shows it to contain emetic, purgative, and narcotic substances, which explains its widespread medicinal use in ancient times. Because the fruit exudes a distinctive and heady fragrance, and its sturdy, forked or intertwined root has torso-like features, the mandrake appears as a widely diffused folkloristic motif associated with aphrodisiac powers. Aphrodite, the Greek goddess of love, beauty, and sex, was given the epithet '*hē mandragoriti*,' 'Lady of the Mandrake.' The Hebrew term *duda’im* is close in sound to *dodim*, 'love.' Indeed, the two are associated in the Song of Songs: 'There I will give my love (*dodai*) to you. / The mandrakes (*duda’im*) yield their fragrance ... my beloved (*dodi*)' (7:13–14).”

God Remembered Noah ... And Rakhel

Up to this point in the Genesis scroll, God has only remembered two other people: Noah and those with him, sitting in the ark waiting for the dry land to appear, and Abraham, who interceded on behalf of Lot sitting in Sodom.

Noah	Abraham	Rachel
Gen. 8:1 And Elohim remembered Noah and all the living creatures and all the beasts that were with him in the ark, and Elohim caused a Spirit/wind to pass over the land, and the waters subsided.	Gen. 19:29 And it came about when Yahweh caused the ruin of the cities of the valley, that he remembered Avraham , and he sent Lot out from the middle of the overturning, when he overturned the cities, in which Lot had been dwelling.	Gen. 30:22-23 And Yahweh remembered Rakhel , and he listened to her, and he opened her womb, and she conceived and gave birth to a son,
<i>God Remembered Noah and Rakhel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).</i>		

In all three stories, the characters are in situations where they are not able save or create life on their own initiative. But in each case, the chosen one becomes the object of Yahweh’s mercy, and their plight gains his attention.

Reflection Question

What does [Genesis 29:31-35](#) show us about God’s heart for people?